Next Chapter

NEXTCHAPTER · PRE-EXIT CHECKLIST

Before you leave.
What to do while you still can.

Whether you're planning a departure or bracing for one — the window to protect yourself is now, not after your last day.

IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE AWAY

The five things that matter most

- → Your personal contacts, references, and work samples belong to you — but only if you save them before you leave
- → COBRA and benefits decisions have hard deadlines. Know them before your last day.
- → Secure references while the relationship is warm and the specific work is fresh
- → Understand what you signed — your non-compete, IP assignment, and severance terms
- → Leave well. The way you exit is the story told about you in your professional network for years.

Most people treat their last day as a finish line. It's actually a deadline — and there's work to do before it arrives.

The access you have today — to your files, your contacts, your performance data, your references — disappears the moment you're out. A few hours of preparation now protects years of work.

CONTACTS AND RELATIONSHIPS

Save what's yours before you lose access

Export your contacts

Every email system — Outlook, Gmail, company systems — allows contact export. Do it before your last day. These are relationships you built. The company does not own them.

- [ ] Export contacts from Outlook / Gmail to CSV
- [ ] Export LinkedIn connections (Settings → Data Privacy → Get a copy of your data → Connections)
- [ ] Note the email addresses of 10–15 key relationships you want to stay in contact with
- [ ] Connect on LinkedIn with any colleagues you haven't connected with yet

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Secure your references now — not when you need them

The best time to ask for a reference is while the relationship is active, the work is recent, and your departure is amicable. Ask before your last day. Brief each person: what role you're targeting, two or three things you'd like them to mention.

- [ ] Identify 5 potential references: a manager, a peer, a direct report, a client or cross-functional partner, and one stretch reference (someone impressive who knows your work)
- [ ] Message each one personally before your last day
- [ ] Ask if they'd be willing and brief them on your next chapter
- [ ] Get personal email addresses — company addresses will stop working

> **NEXTCHAPTER TOOL**
> Victoria's Reference Manager tracks who you've asked, what they said they'd emphasize, and when to follow up — so your references are organized and ready when any company asks.

YOUR WORK AND ACCOMPLISHMENTS

Evidence you're allowed to keep

Document your accomplishments while you have the data

Revenue figures, team sizes, cost reductions, launch metrics — you need these for your résumé and interviews. After you leave, you may not remember the exact numbers and you won't have access to verify them.

- [ ] Write down your 5–7 biggest measurable accomplishments with specific numbers
- [ ] Note: team sizes led, budgets managed, revenue influenced, % improvements achieved
- [ ] Screenshot or save any performance reviews, peer feedback, or recognition emails to personal storage

What you can — and cannot — take

- [ ] **OK to keep:** Contacts, your own performance reviews, your own written work (unless created for a client), publicly available company information
- [ ] **Do not take:** Proprietary company data, client lists you didn't personally build, source code, financial models, confidential documents

If unsure: don't take it. The liability is real and the risk is not worth it. Your accomplishments and relationships are enough.

> **NEXTCHAPTER TOOL**
> The Proof Assets builder helps you turn raw accomplishment notes into polished bullets for your résumé, LinkedIn, and interview answers — before you forget the details.

BENEFITS AND FINANCIAL BRIDGE

Hard deadlines you cannot miss

COBRA election: 60 days, but act in 30

You have 60 days after losing employer coverage to elect COBRA continuation. But waiting the full 60 days creates a retroactive coverage gap with potential billing complications. Make the decision within 30 days: COBRA (maintain exact same plan, at full premium) vs. ACA Marketplace (often cheaper, different network).

- [ ] Find out your current employer's premium contribution (how much they pay vs. you pay)
- [ ] Calculate COBRA cost: full premium + 2% admin fee
- [ ] Check healthcare.gov for ACA plan options and costs in your area
- [ ] If you have ongoing prescriptions or providers: check network before switching

Severance: read it before you sign

Most severance agreements require you to waive certain legal rights in exchange for payment. You typically have 21 days to consider it (45 days for group layoffs) and 7 days to revoke after signing. You do not have to sign immediately. Have someone review it if anything is unclear.

- [ ] Read the full agreement before signing anything
- [ ] Note: what claims are you releasing? What non-disparagement clauses exist?
- [ ] Negotiate: vesting acceleration, extended benefits, a later end date — all possible before you sign
- [ ] If significant: consult an employment attorney before signing

Other benefits to address before your last day

- [ ] File any pending expense reports
- [ ] Use any remaining FSA balance — FSA funds often do not carry over
- [ ] Check your vesting schedule: any equity or 401k match that will vest soon?
- [ ] File for unemployment benefits on your first day of unemployment — not weeks later
- [ ] Get personal copies of any company-sponsored certifications or licenses

> **NEXTCHAPTER TOOL**
>
> The Benefits & Financial Bridge walks you through COBRA vs. ACA, severance review, and runway calculation in your first NextChapter session. Free at **launchyournextchapter.com**

WHAT YOU SIGNED

Know your agreements before you leave

Non-compete clause

Enforceability varies by state (California, North Dakota, and Minnesota barely enforce them; others enforce broadly). Scope, geography, and duration all matter. Know what yours says before you start a search — not after you receive an offer from a competitor.

- [ ] Find your employment agreement and read the non-compete clause
- [ ] Note: which companies are named? What geography? What time period?
- [ ] If broad and you're in an enforcing state: consult an employment attorney before accepting competing offers

IP assignment and NDAs

Standard IP assignment clauses give your employer ownership of work created during employment. Some are written broadly enough to include personal projects. Know what's covered so you don't inadvertently violate it after leaving.

- [ ] Read your IP assignment clause — specifically whether it includes personal time and equipment
- [ ] Note any carve-outs or exclusions you negotiated at hire
- [ ] Review any client NDAs you signed — do they have post-employment restrictions?

LEAVE WELL

How you exit is the story people tell

Give appropriate notice. Two weeks for individual contributors; four weeks for senior roles. Write a departure email that is warm, forward-looking, and brief. Transfer knowledge thoroughly. Return equipment promptly. Say goodbye to people individually who matter to you.

The professional community for most industries is smaller than it seems. The hiring manager who interviews you in two years may have gotten a reference call from your last manager in the meantime. Exit as if everyone is watching. They mostly are.

> ONE THING MOST PEOPLE SKIP
>
> Send a personal note — not a group email — to the 10–15 people who matter most to your career. Tell them you're transitioning, what you're focused on next, and that you'd love to stay in touch. Done now, it keeps the relationship warm. Done six months later when you're job-searching, it reads as transactional.